

“ZTE is customising smartphones for Indian users”

In a bid to cash in on the booming smartphone market in India, ZTE India is taking a step towards ‘massive expansion’, launching its first exclusive ‘experience zone’. This zone has been created in Gurgaon, and will enable smartphone lovers to look at and get a feel of ZTE’s devices. The company seems to be optimistic about the market despite the slowdown that the telecom industry is experiencing. ZTE will focus on 4G, high-end devices and phones based on newer platforms including the latest versions of Android and the Firefox mobile operating system. **Diksha P Gupta** from *Open Source For You* spoke to **Amit Saxena**, marketing director, ZTE, about the company’s strategy in India and its future plans.

Amit Saxena,
marketing director, ZTE



Q In 2012, you had planned to enter the open market in India, but you finally did so only in 2013. Any reasons for the delay?

That is the result of our go-to-market strategy. The market situation in 2012 was different compared to 2013. We saw 2013 as the best time to enter the open market, keeping in mind the high adoption rate of smartphones in the country.

Q You had launched some high-end smartphones in China, which were never brought to the Indian market. What the Indian market got from ZTE initially were some entry level phones with basic specifications.

India is a different market with operators that have different policies. People now have the option of choosing two numbers. So we will now bring in dual SIM models that can help them operate two numbers at a time.

Q How many smartphone models does ZTE have in India currently?

ZTE has a range of 40 smartphones worldwide that are ready to be launched in India. They have been customised as per Indian requirements. We are already supplying to the

operators, but as far as our open market business is concerned, we have just entered our first phase with the launch of four handsets. In Phase 2, which should begin in the next two months, we are launching four more handsets and will add more in the open market gradually, depending on Indian customers’ requirements.

Q What do you mean by ‘customising the handsets for the Indian customers’?

If you look at the global handsets, they are designed keeping in mind different network conditions. Indian network conditions and the way people operate their smartphones are pretty different from customers in the US and UK. In the US, I can live with a smartphone with less battery backup. Those markets do not focus much on the physical housing of the handsets, nor on battery backup or whether the phone has dual SIM capability or not. Customers there are more keen to own feature rich smartphones and are passionate about the speed the device offers. The Indian market is totally different in that sense. Here, people demand more on the hardware and software side, but at an economical cost. An Indian customer’s basic requirements include a huge